

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Silent comedy

DIRECTOR

Charlie Chaplin

WRITER

Charlie Chaplin

STARS

Charlie Chaplin, Virginia Merrill, Harry Myers

BEFORE

1921 Chaplin makes his first feature movie, *The Kid*, with 13-year-old Lita Grey, whom he marries three years later.

1925 Chaplin's *The Gold Rush*, his first blockbuster featuring the Tramp, is a huge success.

1927 The silent era comes to an end with *The Jazz Singer*, the first feature-length movie with full sound dialogue.

AFTER

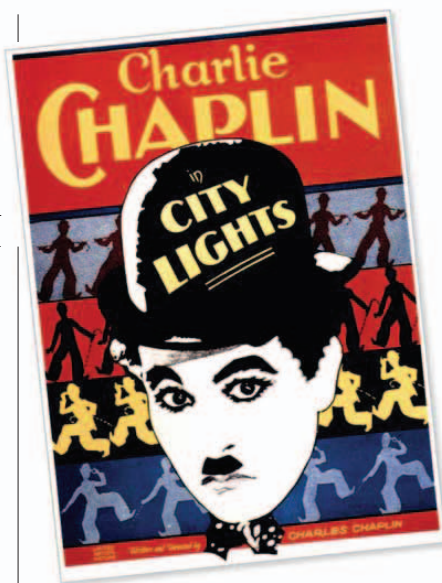
1936 Chaplin makes *Modern Times*, his last silent feature, a protest against the Great Depression workers' conditions.

Charlie Chaplin's movie *City Lights*—which he wrote, directed, and starred in—was one of the last great movies of the silent era, acknowledged by many as one of the best comedies of all time. Although it was released in 1931, four years after the first real talkie, *The Jazz Singer*, Chaplin defiantly made *City Lights* a silent movie with only a few distorted sound effects and a sound track of his own music.

Tramp and the Flower Girl

The story begins in a large city, where Chaplin's Tramp is fleeing from a policeman who threatens to arrest him for vagrancy. Escaping by climbing through a car, he meets a poor blind flower girl (played by Virginia Merrill). He buys a flower from her with his last coin, and the girl, hearing the sound of a luxury car door, believes he is a wealthy man.

Not judged as a vagrant by this blind girl, the Tramp falls in love with her and wants to be the rich and handsome benefactor she imagines him to be. He determines to rescue her from her life of poverty and when he hears of an operation that will restore her sight, he



The poster for the movie's original release in 1931 makes full use of the audience's recognition of Chaplin's Tramp persona.

searches desperately for ways to raise the money to fund it, from sweeping the streets to getting beaten in a prizefight—vehicles for Chaplin's trademark slapstick, bawdiness, and melodrama.

The Tramp also saves a millionaire who is threatening to commit suicide after his wife has left him. In return, the millionaire offers the Tramp \$1,000 to help the girl. Unfortunately, the millionaire only sees the Tramp as a friend when he is blind drunk. When the millionaire sobers up, he accuses the Tramp of stealing the money. Going on the run, the Tramp gives the girl the money to pay for the sight operation, but is captured and thrown in jail.

A touching encounter

Finally, he is released from jail and finds himself outside the flower shop. In the window, the girl is arranging flowers. She has had the operation and can see. Full of



Charlie Chaplin Director

Actor-director Charlie Chaplin was the biggest star of silent movies. Born

in London in 1889, he survived a childhood beset by poverty. His alcoholic father abandoned his singer mother, who was later committed to an asylum. These early experiences inspired the character of the outcast Tramp. As a teenager, Chaplin joined a circus troupe and an impresario

took him to the US. By age 26, he was a star with his own movie company. He made a string of hit silent movies before his first talkie, the anti-Hitler satire *The Great Dictator*. He died in 1977.

Key movies

1921 *The Kid*
1925 *The Gold Rush*
1931 *City Lights*
1936 *Modern Times*
1940 *The Great Dictator*